

Cottage Food Compliance Kit

Designed to help you keep state requirements, label checks, registrations, and sales totals organized in one place with regular verification steps.

Galaxy Forge Implementation Kit | Version 1.0 | September 2026

Companion files: Excel workbook, editable Word templates, README.

Cottage Food Compliance Kit - Operator Guide

Disclosure First - Read Before You Use Anything Else

This guide is an organizational and educational tool only. It is not legal advice. Food rules vary by state, county, and city, and they change often. Verify your state rules locally with your state health department or department of agriculture before you produce, label, price, or sell any food. If your product, label, kitchen, or sales channel does not fit your state cottage food rule, do not sell under that rule. Talk with a licensed attorney or your local regulator when you are unsure.

The 2025 reforms referenced in this kit concern Texas, Vermont, Iowa, Oklahoma, Nevada, and Minnesota. Each of those states adjusted some combination of caps, allowed foods, registration steps, or direct-sales provisions. The details below describe the kinds of changes to look for, not the final text of any statute. Because agencies issue guidance after a statute passes, the agency page you read in January can differ from the page you read in June. The State Requirements Tracker in the workbook exists for exactly this reason: every row carries a Last Verified Date and a Verification Source so you always know how fresh your notes are.

Who This Kit Serves

This kit serves US home-based food producers who make allowed cottage foods in a home kitchen and sell direct to consumers through farmers markets, roadside stands, farm stands, pop-up events, or home delivery where the state permits it. Typical products include baked goods that do not require refrigeration, jams and jellies, dry mixes, granola, popcorn, candy, dried herbs, and similar shelf-stable items where allowed. If you use a co-packer, sell wholesale to grocery stores, produce foods that require continuous refrigeration for safety, or operate a licensed commercial kitchen, this kit alone does not cover your situation. The listing file explains who this kit is for and who it is not for in more detail.

How To Use This Kit

Work in this order. First, open the State Requirements Tracker and enter each state where you sell or plan to sell. Record the annual cap, registration requirement, allowed foods, and label wording, then verify each item against the current agency source and stamp the Last Verified Date. Second, open the Registration Log and enter every training certificate, registration, permit, and renewal with confirmation numbers and due dates. Third, build each product label with the label template, then check it in the Label Compliance Checker, including the nine-allergen review and the home-kitchen warning. Fourth, log sales monthly in the Sales Cap Tracker and review remaining-under-cap before accepting large or recurring orders. Fifth, print the signage text and keep a binder or folder with registrations, labels, and logs for market day.

Repeat the cycle on a fixed cadence. A simple rhythm is: verify state rows once per month, check every label version before each print run, enter sales within two days of each market, and review renewals on the first Monday of each month. Small, regular entries prevent the end-of-year scramble where caps surprise operators and renewals lapse.

Background - What Cottage Food Rules Are

Cottage food rules are state laws that permit limited production of specific low-risk foods in a home kitchen without the full commercial food license, subject to conditions. The core idea is proportionality: a person selling a few hundred loaves of bread at a farmers market faces different requirements than a plant shipping pallets across state lines. To keep that distinction workable, states draw lines around four things: which foods are allowed, how much you can sell, where and to whom you can sell, and what your label must say.

Allowed foods are usually shelf-stable items with low food-safety hazard under normal handling. Common examples include breads, rolls, cookies, cakes that do not need refrigeration, fruit jams with standard sugar and acid profiles, dry baking mixes, granola, roasted coffee, dried pasta, popcorn, and candies. Foods that typically fall outside cottage rules include meat, fresh dairy, cut fresh produce sold as ready-to-eat meals, low-acid canned vegetables, garlic-in-oil mixtures, and any product that must stay refrigerated or frozen to remain safe, unless the state explicitly permits it with added conditions. Your state publishes an allowed-foods list or a set of exclusions. Copy that list into the Notes column of your tracker and date it.

Sales caps limit annual gross or net sales under the cottage provision. Some states set a single flat cap. Others use tiers where a higher cap triggers added training, registration, or inspection. Caps may count all cottage sales combined or apply per product line, and they may include or exclude certain channels. Because the counting method matters as much as the number, record both the cap figure and the counting rule in your tracker. The Sales Cap Tracker in this kit treats the cap as a planning threshold you enter yourself; it does not supply the legal figure for your state.

Sales channels describe where cottage food may change hands. Many states permit farmers markets, roadside stands, farm stands, community events, and direct home delivery. Some permit mail or online sales within the state with conditions. Few permit wholesale, interstate shipment, or grocery consignment under the cottage provision. Channel rules interact with caps: a state may allow a higher cap for in-person direct sales and a lower one for shipped sales, or it may exclude shipped sales

entirely. When you read your state rule, highlight the channel sentence and copy it verbatim into your tracker notes with the source date.

Registration describes what you file before you sell. At the light end, a state may require only a food-handler training certificate kept on file. In the middle, it may require an online registration with name, address, product list, and acknowledgment of the rules. At the more involved end, it may require a home-kitchen self-certification, water-test documentation for well water, a label sample, and a renewal each year or every two years. Fees range from zero to a modest annual amount. Keep the confirmation for every filing in the Registration Log with the renewal date, because lapsed paperwork is one of the most common market-day problems.

Label rules describe what the package must show. Nearly every state requires the product name, net weight or volume, full ingredient list in descending order by weight, producer name and physical address, and allergen information consistent with federal expectations. Many states add a home-kitchen statement such as language stating the food was made in a home kitchen not subject to routine inspection. Font-size, placement, and exact wording vary. The label template and Label Compliance Checker in this kit walk through each panel so you review the same items in the same order every time.

State-By-State Variance - Why One Checklist Cannot Fit All States

New operators often ask for a single national checklist. No such checklist can be accurate, because the underlying statutes differ on nearly every material point. One state may cap annual sales at a figure in the low tens of thousands while a neighboring state permits multiples of that amount. One state may require ingredient weights on the label while another requires only ordered ingredient names. One state may allow direct online sales within its borders while another restricts sales to in-person handoffs. Treating a neighboring state rule as your own is one of the fastest ways to mislabel or oversell.

Consider caps as an illustration. A flat-cap state gives you one number to watch. A tiered state gives you two numbers and a decision: stay under the lower threshold with lighter paperwork, or accept the higher threshold with added training or registration. A per-product state requires separate running totals. An illustrative example follows, labeled as such: an operator selling baked goods and jam in a flat-cap state enters 50000 as the annual cap and logs combined monthly net sales against it, while the same operator in a tiered state enters the lower threshold as an early-warning line and the higher threshold as the hard planning line, with a note on what filing the higher tier requires. Both entries are illustrative examples only; your actual cap and counting rule come from your current state source.

Registration variance is equally wide. An illustrative example: one state asks for a food-handler card plus a one-page online registration renewed every two years, while another asks for annual registration with a product list and a label sample attached. The workbook handles both by treating registration as a log of filings with dates and confirmations rather than assuming any particular form. When your state changes its form, you add a row; you do not need a new system.

Label variance centers on wording and placement. Most states require the same core panels, but the home-kitchen sentence differs word for word, and some states require it in a minimum type size or on the front panel rather than the back. Allergen expectations add a further layer: federal law identifies nine major allergens, and states incorporate that expectation into cottage labels in slightly different

ways. The allergen-label module in this kit, described in full later, reviews all nine on every product regardless of state, then adds the state-specific facility warning exactly as your state phrases it.

The 2025 reforms in Texas, Vermont, Iowa, Oklahoma, Nevada, and Minnesota illustrate why dated verification matters. Across those states, reform activity touched sales caps, allowed-food definitions, registration mechanics, and direct-sales provisions such as delivery or intrastate shipment. The practical effect for an operator is not that one reform helps everyone; it is that any row in your tracker dated before the reform may now be stale. If you sell in any of those six states, re-verify the cap figure, the allowed-foods list, the registration form, and the channel sentence against a source dated after the reform, then stamp the new date. If you sell elsewhere, treat those six states as a reminder that your own state can revise its rule with similar notice.

Method - The Monthly Compliance Routine

This kit uses a four-part routine that fits on one calendar page: verify, log, check, total. Verify means re-reading your state rows and confirming nothing changed. Log means entering registrations, trainings, and renewals with confirmations. Check means reviewing each label version before it prints, including allergens. Total means entering monthly sales and comparing the running total to the cap. Each part takes minutes when done monthly and hours when deferred to year end.

Start each month with verification. Open the State Requirements Tracker, sort by Last Verified Date, and re-open the oldest source link. If the agency page matches your row, update the Last Verified Date and move on. If it differs, update the changed cell, note the reform or guidance date, and flag any label or cap consequence. A ten-minute monthly pass keeps reform surprises small.

Continue with the Registration Log. Confirm that every status still reads Active or that pending items have a follow-up date. Check the Days To Renewal column for anything under sixty days and calendar the renewal task. File new confirmations behind the cover sheet so the binder mirrors the log. If two people share the business, assign one owner for log entries so handwriting or file-naming stays consistent.

Then check labels. Pull the Label Compliance Checker and filter for HOLD rows. No HOLD label prints until its Fix Needed cell is cleared and a second look confirms the fix on the actual proof, not just in the spreadsheet. For every new product or recipe change, add a fresh row rather than overwriting the old one, so you keep a history of what shipped under which label version.

Close the month with totals. Enter monthly sales and refunds in the Sales Cap Tracker, confirm Net Monthly Sales and Running Year Total compute correctly, and read Remaining Under Cap and Percent Of Cap Used before committing to wholesale-style bulk orders, holiday pre-sales, or subscription boxes. If the percent climbs faster than the calendar, slow intake or shift effort to products with clearer margin rather than drifting over the cap.

Workflow 1 - Verifying Your State Rules Locally

Verifying locally means going to the primary source, reading the current text, and writing down what you found with a date. Secondary summaries, videos, and market-neighbor advice can orient you, but they do not replace the agency page or the statute. Your tracker has a Verification Source column for this reason: paste the page title and access date so a future you can tell whether a row reflects current

text or memory.

A practical pass looks like this. Open your state health department or agriculture department cottage food page. Confirm the allowed-foods section and copy any new exclusions. Confirm the cap figure and whether the page says gross or net, per-producer or per-product, and which channels count. Confirm registration steps, fees, and renewal periods. Confirm label requirements including the exact home-kitchen sentence and allergen expectations. Confirm channel permissions for markets, delivery, and intrastate shipment. Paste or summarize each answer in the tracker with the date. If the page links to a statute or administrative rule, save that link too, because guidance pages sometimes lag the underlying text after a reform.

For the six 2025-reform states, add one extra step: search the agency site for a reform FAQ or transition memo dated 2025. Transition memos often answer the questions operators actually ask, such as whether sales made before the effective date count toward the new cap, whether existing registrations carry over, and whether old label stock may be used through a grace period. If no memo exists, call or email the listed program contact and log the answer with the responder name, office, date, and a one-sentence summary. Keep that note with your registration file.

County and city rules deserve a separate check. Some farmers markets require vendor permits, temporary food-facility paperwork, or proof of training beyond the state cottage registration. Some cities restrict home-business signage, customer pickup traffic, or commercial delivery frequency in residential zones. These are not cottage food rules, but they can stop a market day just as firmly. Add a row for market-level requirements in the Notes column or on a second line under the state so the binder shows both layers.

Workflow 2 - Confirming Product Eligibility Before You Scale A Recipe

Before you scale any recipe, confirm three things: the food type is allowed, the process is allowed, and the storage is allowed. A food type can be allowed while a process is not. An illustrative example, labeled as such: plain baked bread may be allowed while the same dough filled with meat or custard and sold at room temperature is not, because the filling changes the hazard profile. Another illustrative example: fruit jam made with standard sugar and acid procedures may be allowed while low-sugar, low-acid, or vegetable canning with water-bath-only processing is restricted or excluded. The distinction turns on safety characteristics, not on taste or popularity.

Read your allowed-foods list with a highlighter. Mark each product you sell and each product you plan to add. For each planned product, write one sentence on why it fits the list, citing the list line. If you cannot cite a line, treat the product as not cleared and seek agency clarification before selling it. Keep that one-sentence fit note in the product file; it makes future additions faster and keeps holiday experimentation inside the allowed set.

Process review comes next. Note the cooking, baking, drying, or mixing method, the pH or water-activity control where relevant, and the cooling and packing steps. Cottage rules rarely ask for a full hazard plan, but writing the steps in plain order helps you spot a product that needs refrigeration to stay safe. If a product must stay cold to remain safe and your state limits cottage food to shelf-stable items, that product does not belong in the cottage line. Move it to a licensed-kitchen plan or drop it rather than stretching the cottage definition.

Storage and transport close the loop. Confirm that the product stays safe at ambient temperature through packing, market display, delivery, and reasonable customer storage. If your state permits direct delivery, confirm time and temperature expectations for the delivery window. An illustrative example: an operator who delivers baked goods in summer heat packs boxes to limit crushing and moisture, keeps delivery runs short, and prints a same-day freshness note rather than a multi-day room-temperature storage claim. That is an illustrative handling choice, not a safety certification.

Workflow 3 - Registration, Training, And Renewal Logging

Treat paperwork as inventory: every certificate and confirmation has a location, a status, and a due date. The Registration Log gives each filing one row with type, state, submitted date, confirmation number, fee paid, status, renewal due date, days to renewal, office contact, and notes. The cover-sheet template summarizes the active filings on one page for market managers who ask for proof.

Enter training first. Many states require a food-handler course from an approved provider. Log the provider, completion date, certificate number, and expiration. Keep a PDF or photocopy with the log. If two people produce food, log both certificates; a single certificate rarely covers an entire household team.

Enter registrations next. For each state registration, log the submitted date, confirmation number, listed products, listed address, and renewal period. Attach the product list you submitted so later additions are visible as changes. If the state asks for a label sample, attach the exact version you sent and mark its date, because later label revisions can drift from the filed sample.

Watch renewals with the Days To Renewal formula, which subtracts today from the renewal due date. Positive numbers count down; negative numbers mean overdue. Review this column on the first Monday of each month and calendar any renewal inside sixty days. Renewal lapses often coincide with peak market season, so a winter renewal review that fronts the spring deadlines repays its time quickly.

Label Anatomy - What Goes Where On A Cottage Food Label

A cottage food label typically carries five panels or zones even when printed on a single sticker: identity, net quantity, ingredients, allergen and facility information, and producer contact. Order and wording follow state text, but the function of each zone is consistent across states.

Identity states the common name of the food in plain words. Use names customers recognize, such as Honey Oat Loaf or Strawberry Jam, and avoid fanciful names that obscure what the food is. If the product has a flavor or variant, include it in the identity line so the front of the package matches the ingredient list. An illustrative example: Chocolate Chip Banana Bread names the base and the characterizing inclusion in one line, which helps both customers and reviewers match the package to the recipe file.

Net quantity states how much food is in the package, excluding packaging. Most cottage labels use ounces and grams or fluid ounces and milliliters. Place it on the front panel where the state requires, and print it in the minimum type size the rule sets. Verify whether your state wants net weight at pack time and whether reasonable moisture loss in baked goods needs any special handling in your records. When in doubt, weigh a sample of packed units and keep the tare-weight note in the product file.

Ingredients list every component by common name in descending order by weight as added, including sub-ingredients for mixes, coatings, and fillings. For example, a baking mix that contains flour, sugar, and a prepared chocolate chip lists the chip sub-ingredients in parentheses after the chip entry. List colors, flavorings, and preservatives by name. Keep the list on one panel in legible type and avoid splitting it across a fold where words can be lost.

Producer contact gives the maker name and physical address where the food was produced, plus a phone or email for questions. Some states permit a mailing address or a market-stall address in addition to the production address; others require the production address itself. Copy the address rule into your tracker and follow it exactly. Customers with allergy or storage questions need a working contact, so test the listed email or phone before each print run.

The allergen and facility zone is covered in depth in the next two sections because it carries the highest consequence for error. In short, it declares the nine major allergens present in plain words and carries the home-kitchen warning exactly as the state phrases it.

Allergen-Label Module Part 1 - The Nine Major Allergens On Every Product

Federal expectations recognize nine major allergens: milk, eggs, fish, shellfish, tree nuts, peanuts, wheat, sesame, and soy. Cottage labels incorporate that expectation even when the state sentence is brief. Review all nine on every product and every recipe revision, including products that appear plain. Sesame in particular hides in blends, coatings, and toppings where operators least expect it, and tree nuts branch into many species that share a declaration family.

Build the review into the recipe file, not just the label proof. For each ingredient, list known allergen content from the supplier label. For each sub-ingredient, carry the allergen forward. An illustrative example, labeled as such: a granola with oats, honey, sunflower oil, and a prepared vanilla chip carries forward milk and soy from the chip sub-ingredients even though the oats and honey themselves contain neither. Without the sub-ingredient pass, the front oats-and-honey story would understate the actual allergen content. That is why the Label Compliance Checker asks Nine Major Allergens Reviewed as a separate Y/N from Allergen Declaration Text Present: the first confirms you did the review, the second confirms you printed the result.

Write Contains statements in plain words. A common pattern is: Contains: Wheat, Milk, Soy. Use the ordinary food-group words your customers recognize rather than Latin or technical terms. If the product contains fish, shellfish, or tree nuts, name the species or type in words, such as Contains: Almond, or Contains: Shrimp, alongside the group where your state pattern calls for it. Keep the Contains line adjacent to the ingredient list or where your state directs, and keep it in type that remains legible on the smallest package you sell.

Handle shared equipment with care. If allergens are present in your kitchen on shared pans, mixers, or surfaces, do not rely on cleaning memory. Write the cleaning steps you actually follow, decide whether a may-contain or shared-equipment note is truthful for your process, and keep the note factual. An illustrative example: Made in a home kitchen that also processes wheat, milk, tree nuts, and soy. Shared equipment cleaned between batches. That sentence is an illustrative example of tone and structure, not a required legal phrase. Copy your state wording where the state prescribes it, and keep any additional note truthful and narrow.

Re-review on every supplier or recipe change. A new vanilla, a different chocolate chip, a bulk flour switch, or a seasonal topping can introduce sesame, soy, or tree nuts without changing the product name. The checker workflow treats any ingredient change as a new label version with a fresh row and a fresh date. That discipline costs one extra row per change and prevents the most common allergen miss: the unchanged front label on a changed recipe.

Allergen-Label Module Part 2 - Home-Kitchen Warning, Placement, And Customer Communication

Many states require a home-kitchen statement on the label in addition to allergen declarations. Typical meaning, in plain terms: this food was made in a home kitchen not subject to routine inspection by the health department. Exact wording, capitalization, punctuation, and placement vary by state. Copy the required sentence character for character from the current agency source into the label template field, and do not paraphrase it. If the state requires a minimum type size or front-panel placement, follow that instruction first and fit design around it.

Place the facility warning where the rule says. When the rule is silent on placement, a reliable default is directly below the Contains line on the same panel, so allergy and facility information sit together where a concerned customer naturally looks. Keep both lines clear of folds, seals, and stickers that can cover words in transit. Proof the actual printed size, not just the screen proof, because a legible screen line can shrink below legibility on a two-inch jar lid.

Support the label with spoken and posted communication. The signage template includes a market-stall sign stating the food was made in a home kitchen, a take-home allergen notice with contact information, and short staff talking points. Train anyone who sells for you to read the label verbatim when asked about ingredients rather than answering from memory. An illustrative example of a spoken reply, labeled as such: Let me read you the ingredient and allergen lines from this exact package, and here is our contact if you need more detail. That reply is an illustrative example of careful service, not a script required by law.

Keep an ingredient binder at the stall for custom and seasonal items. The binder holds the current ingredient list and allergen line for each product, the supplier allergen notes for prepared components, and the date each page was last updated. When a customer asks about a sample or a custom order, open the binder to the dated page and read from it. Replace binder pages on the same day a label version changes so the spoken answer and the printed label never diverge.

Net Weight, Ingredient Order, And Producer Address In Practice

Net-weight accuracy depends on tare discipline. Weigh the empty package with lid, tie, or clamshell, record the tare, then weigh packed units and subtract. An illustrative example: if empty jars with lids average 6.2 ounces and packed jars average 14.2 ounces, the net content averages 8.0 ounces for that sample, labeled as such as an illustrative example. Check several units, not one, because hand-packed cottage goods vary. If variation is wide, adjust the fill procedure or the declared weight so the label remains truthful across the batch.

Ingredient order follows weight as added, not volume or perceived importance. Weigh or compute formula weights for the batch, sort descending, and write the list in that order. Carry sub-ingredients through in parentheses. An illustrative example: a cookie with flour, butter, sugar, eggs, and prepared toffee bits lists flour first if flour weighs most in the batch formula, with toffee sub-ingredients in parentheses after the toffee entry. That ordering example is illustrative; your order follows your actual formula weights.

Producer-address compliance is literal. If the rule says physical production address, print the street, city, state, and ZIP where the food was made. If the rule permits an alternate contact address in addition, you may add it, but do not replace the required line. Test the listed phone or email quarterly. A disconnected contact on an allergy question undermines the entire label effort.

Sales-Cap Tracking With Formulas - Method And Routine

The Sales Cap Tracker answers two questions every month: where do we stand, and how fast are we approaching the cap. It does so with five computed columns. Net Monthly Sales subtracts returns and refunds from monthly sales. Running Year Total accumulates net sales across the year. Remaining Under Cap subtracts the running total from the annual cap you entered. Percent Of Cap Used divides the running total by the cap. Each formula is shown in the workbook file so you can audit the math.

Enter one row per month per state where you sell. If you sell in two states with different caps, keep separate row groups so each running total compares against its own cap. Record the channel mix in the Notes habit even though the sheet does not enforce it: a brief note such as markets plus roadside, no shipment, helps you interpret the total when channel rules differ. An illustrative example, labeled as such: monthly net sales of 1160, 1500, and 1740 accumulate to a running total of 4400 against a 50000 illustrative cap, leaving 45600 remaining and about 8.8 percent used. Those figures are illustrative examples only; your cap and pace come from your own entries.

Review pace, not just position. Divide percent used by months elapsed for a rough monthly pace, and compare that pace to the months remaining in your cap year. If pace suggests the cap will bind before year end, decide early: pause intake for bulk orders, shift toward products with clearer margin per unit of cap consumed, or prepare the higher-tier filing if your state offers one. Early decisions preserve customer relationships; late discoveries force cancellations.

Reconcile the tracker to cash reality monthly. Compare the sheet total to market settlement reports, delivery logs, and refund notes. Investigate gaps the same week: missing market envelopes, unlogged delivery payments, or refunds recorded in messages but not in the sheet. A tracker that matches cash is useful; one that drifts becomes decoration.

Registration Log Routine And Renewal Discipline

The Registration Log works when entries happen at filing time, not at renewal time. Enter the submitted date, confirmation number, fee, and renewal due date on the day you file, and attach the confirmation the same day. The Days To Renewal column then counts down automatically. A row entered late is better than a missing row, but same-day entry is the standard to hold.

Set two renewal alerts per filing: a sixty-day planning alert and a fourteen-day action alert. At sixty days, confirm the renewal form, fee, product list, and label sample requirements have not changed. At

fourteen days, file and log the new confirmation. If a filing shows Pending, add a follow-up date within two weeks and keep the pending letter or email with the file. Pending registrations have a way of stalling without a dated nudge.

Keep training certificates alongside registrations. If your state ties the registration to a current food-handler card, align the renewal review so both dates are checked together. When household help changes, update the training rows before the next market rather than after a manager asks.

Market-Day And Delivery-Day Checklists

Pack the binder before you pack the product. Market binder contents: current registrations and training certificates, the active label version for each product on the table, the State Requirements Tracker summary page, the Registration Log cover sheet, the ingredient binder pages, and the customer allergen notice stack. Delivery-bag contents for direct delivery: product with final labels, a packing slip with producer contact, and the allergen notice where your procedure calls for it.

Pre-market label sweep: pull one unit of each product, read the front identity, net weight, ingredient list, Contains line, facility warning, and producer contact against the checker row, and initial the row. If any unit differs from the approved proof, hold that product until the label is corrected. Post-market entry: log gross sales, refunds, and fees the same evening or the next morning so the monthly total stays honest.

Delivery-day additions: confirm the delivery addresses are within your permitted channel, keep the delivery log with times, and keep products within the handling conditions your procedure specifies. An illustrative example: a short delivery window with insulated totes for heat-sensitive icing, logged by stop time, labeled as an illustrative example of careful handling rather than a safety standard.

Illustrative Examples - Labeled As Such

Example 1, illustrative example: a home baker sells two breads and one jam at a weekly market in a flat-cap state. The baker enters an illustrative cap of 50000, logs monthly net sales, and reviews percent used before accepting a holiday pre-order for 200 loaves. The pre-order decision uses remaining-under-cap plus production capacity: if the cap accommodates the order and the kitchen schedule does, the baker confirms; if not, the baker caps the pre-order quantity and explains the limit in plain terms. Figures and facts in this paragraph are illustrative examples.

Example 2, illustrative example: a jam maker revises a recipe to use a new pectin blend. The ingredient list changes, so the maker adds a new checker row, re-reviews all nine allergens including soy and sesame that sometimes appear in blends, reprints the Contains line, updates the binder page the same day, and files the old label version with its retirement date. No sales occur under the old ingredient list after the switch date. Facts in this paragraph are illustrative examples.

Example 3, illustrative example: an operator in one of the 2025-reform states reads a transition memo stating that existing registrations carry over but new label wording applies to stock printed after the effective date. The operator logs the memo date and source, uses existing printed stock through the stated grace window where permitted, and prints the new facility sentence on the next run. The operator stamps the tracker row with the new verification date. Facts in this paragraph are illustrative examples.

Common Label Errors And Fixes

Missing Contains line even when allergens are present. Fix: add the Contains line on every product with any of the nine allergens, and add a truthful shared-equipment note where applicable. Review the proof at print size.

Incomplete sub-ingredients. Fix: expand prepared components with parenthetical sub-ingredients from the supplier label, then re-sort the full list by weight.

Paraphrased facility warning. Fix: replace the paraphrase with the exact state sentence, character for character, and confirm placement and size.

Wrong or missing address. Fix: print the address type the rule requires and test the contact. Keep the rule sentence in the tracker.

Net-weight drift. Fix: re-tare, re-sample, and adjust fill or declared weight so packed units match the label across the batch.

Stale label after recipe change. Fix: treat every ingredient or supplier change as a new version with a new checker row and same-day binder update.

Record Retention And Binder Setup

Keep registrations, label versions, sales logs, and verification notes for at least the period your state requires, and longer if you sell the same product across calendar years. A simple binder order is: cover sheet, active registrations and certificates, state tracker summary, active label proofs, retired label versions with dates, monthly sales summaries, and correspondence with regulators. Mirror the binder in a dated folder backup with PDFs or photos. Name files with product, version, and date so sorting is automatic.

Retire label versions cleanly. When a version is replaced, mark the old proof retired with the last sale date under that version, move it behind the active proofs, and update the binder index. If a customer question later concerns an older unit, the retired proof shows exactly what that unit carried.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can I sell in two states under cottage rules. Possibly, but each state rule applies to sales in that state. Maintain separate tracker rows, separate verification dates, and separate cap totals. Verify your state rules locally in each state.

Do I need a separate allergen product or certificate. This kit includes the allergen-label module inside the checker and label template. No separate allergen product is included. Training certificates depend on state rules; log whatever your state requires.

What if my product contains none of the nine allergens. State the review result truthfully per your state pattern and keep the facility warning where required. Do not claim allergen-free production unless that claim is truthful for your kitchen and permitted by your state wording. When in doubt, describe what you do rather than making a sweeping claim.

How do I handle seasonal or custom flavors. Treat each flavor as its own label version with its own checker row, ingredient list, and allergen review. Custom orders carry the same labeling duty as market

stock.

Can I ship or sell online. Only where your state permits, and only in the manner it permits. Copy the channel sentence into your tracker and follow it. Interstate shipment under cottage rules is commonly restricted.

What records do markets usually ask for. Registration or training proof, product list, and sometimes label samples. The cover sheet plus the active proofs usually satisfy a routine ask. Keep copies, not originals, at the table.

How often should I re-verify. Monthly for the oldest tracker row at minimum, immediately when you hear of a reform or guidance update, and before each print run for the label wording. Stamp every check with a date.

Do I need nutrition facts. Cottage rules often use small-producer provisions, but the details depend on product, sales volume, and claims made. Verify your state rules locally and seek qualified guidance before adding nutrient claims.

What if my state has no cottage category for my product. Then do not sell that product under cottage rules. Consider a licensed kitchen, a shared kitchen, or a different product that fits the allowed list.

Limitations

This kit organizes records and label reviews. It does not test food, measure pH or water activity, approve labels, file registrations, or provide legal advice. Example caps, fees, dates, and sales figures in this guide and workbook are illustrative examples only. State reforms can change caps, foods, forms, and channel permissions with limited notice. Some products and processes fall outside cottage rules entirely. Verify your state rules locally before producing, labeling, or selling.

Final Disclosure And Verification Log

Verify your state rules locally. This material is not legal advice. Regulations, caps, allowed foods, registration forms, and label wording change; your dated tracker rows and filed confirmations are the operational proof that you checked. Keep the verification habit monthly, keep label versions dated, keep sales entered promptly, and keep the binder ready for market day. That steady routine is what this kit is designed to support.

Verification log starter: State ____ Source page ____ Date checked ____ Initials ____ . Next review date ____ . Label version ____ Date approved for print ____ Initials ____ . Cap year ____ Cap figure entered ____ Source ____ .

ENDPART3